

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Talking to Yourself Kindly

In December, Jordan started seeing a counselor.

Not Mr. Tate. A different counselor. A grown-up his mother had found, after a long conversation Jordan did not know about, with Jordan's pediatrician.

His mother had told him about it the night before the first appointment.

"Jordan. I want to tell you something. Tomorrow after school, you and I are going to go see a person. Her name is Dr. Mendel. She is somebody who talks to kids. She is going to ask you questions and listen to you. That is what she does."

Jordan had been on the floor of his room building a Lego pirate ship. He had stopped. He had said, in a small voice, *am I in trouble?*

"No, sweetheart. You are not in trouble. You are not. I just — I have been noticing some things this fall. I have been noticing you have been quieter than usual when you think nobody is watching. I have been noticing you laughing very loudly when you think people are watching. I have been noticing you go to bed and not sleep. I have been thinking maybe you would like somebody to talk to who is not me. Somebody who is trained for this. Just to see."

Jordan had looked at the Lego pirate ship.

"You noticed?"

"I noticed, sweetheart. I have been noticing for a while. I am sorry it took me so long to ask."

Jordan, on the floor of his room, had started to cry.

He had cried for almost ten minutes. He had cried in a way he had not cried in maybe two years. His mother had sat down next to him on the floor and put her arm around him and not said anything, just held him, the way mothers are supposed to know how to hold sons who have been carrying things they have not told anybody about.

After he was done crying, Jordan had said, "I have not told anybody."

"What have you not told anybody, sweetheart?"

"That I am sad sometimes. That I do not always want to be funny. That I am tired of being the funny one. That I do not know who I am if I am not the funny one. That sometimes when I am being funny I am — I am not actually inside the funny anymore. I am just watching myself be funny. And I do not feel anything."

His mother had not interrupted.

"I do not know what is wrong with me," Jordan had said. "I am scared something is wrong with me."

His mother had said, "Sweetheart. Nothing is wrong with you. What is happening to you is real. It is not made up. It is also not who you are. It is something that is happening that we are going to figure out together. That is what Dr. Mendel is for. Okay?"

"Okay."

"You do not have to keep being funny if you do not want to. You can put down the funny. The funny is not a job. The funny is one of your gifts. You can use it when you want to and put it away when you do not."

"Okay."

"I love you exactly the same when you are being funny and when you are not. Okay?"

"Okay."

"Okay."

They had hugged for a long time.

The next day, after school, Jordan and his mother went to Dr. Mendel's office. It was a small office in a building near the highway. There were three chairs in the room. Dr. Mendel was a woman with curly gray hair and a yellow cardigan. She looked, Jordan thought, like a grandmother. He had not expected that. He had been picturing somebody in a suit.

Dr. Mendel said, "Hi, Jordan. I'm Pam. You can call me Pam. Is that okay?"

"Yes."

"Your mom told me a little about you. Do you want to tell me anything?"

Jordan looked at his mom. His mom nodded.

"I am a funny kid," said Jordan. "I am — I think I am tired of being the funny kid."

Dr. Pam Mendel said, "Tell me what that means."

Jordan told her.

He told her, in third-grade language, what he had told his mom the night before. He told her about being in his head, watching himself be funny. He told her about going to sleep and not sleeping. He told her about being in third grade and people expecting jokes. He told her about not knowing who he was without the jokes.

Dr. Pam listened.

When he was done, she said, "Jordan. I have a question for you. Are you ready?"

"Okay."

"What does the voice in your head — the unkind voice — say to you?"

Jordan thought. He thought for a long time.

Then he said, "It says — *you are not actually funny. It says — when people laugh at your jokes, they are being nice. It says — you are only the funny kid because if you were not the funny kid you would be nothing. It says — there is nothing else inside you. It says — if you stopped being funny, nobody would have any reason to keep you around.*"

His mother, in the chair next to him, made a small sound. He had not told her this part.

Dr. Pam Mendel did not flinch. She had been doing this for a long time.

"Jordan. Thank you for telling me. That is a hard voice to have inside your head. I want to ask you another question."

"Okay."

"If your best friend told you that voice was in their head — about them — what would you say to them?"

Jordan thought.

"I would say — *that's not true. I would say — you are way more than funny. I would say — even if you weren't funny we would still want you around. I would say — your funny is one part of you, not the whole part.*"

Dr. Pam Mendel nodded.

"Jordan. The voice in your head is not telling you the truth. The voice is telling you a story that helped you, once, when you were small — maybe — but is hurting you now. The voice is not who you are. We are going to spend some time, together, helping you learn to talk back to it."

"How do I talk back to it?"

"You start with the sentence you just said. The thing you would say to your best friend. You say it to yourself. Out loud,

or in your head. You practice. Every day. As many times a day as the unkind voice shows up. You do not try to make the unkind voice go away. You just give it a second voice — the kind voice — that says the true thing."

"That is what we are going to work on. It is going to take some time. It is not a one-day fix. You will come see me once a week for a while, and we will practice. Sometimes here. Sometimes you will practice at home. Sometimes you will practice in the middle of class. Whenever the unkind voice shows up — you practice."

"Okay," said Jordan.

He felt — and he did not have words for this in the moment — he felt believed. Dr. Pam Mendel had heard him say *the voice tells me there is nothing else inside me*, and she had not laughed, and she had not said *oh that is silly*, and she had not said *of course there is a lot inside you, you funny boy*. She had just — taken it seriously. The way she would have taken it seriously if a grown-up had said the same thing.

Jordan had not had anybody take him seriously like that in a long time. He had been a funny kid. Funny kids do not always get taken seriously, because the funny gets in the way.

Dr. Pam had moved the funny out of the way and looked at him.

He thought he might like her.

By the end of the appointment, Jordan and his mom had a plan. Jordan would come back next week. He would come back every week for a few months. They would see how things went. There were a few small things he would do at home in the meantime. One of the small things — Dr. Pam wrote it down on a piece of paper for him — was:

EVERY NIGHT BEFORE BED, JORDAN WILL WRITE DOWN ONE TRUE THING ABOUT HIMSELF THAT IS NOT ABOUT

BEING FUNNY.

That was the homework.

Jordan took the piece of paper. He folded it carefully. He put it in his pocket.

He and his mom got in the car and drove home.

That night, in his room, before bed, Jordan opened his journal — the school one, the one Ms. Calloway had given him at the end of Unit One — and he wrote, on a fresh page:

ONE TRUE THING ABOUT ME THAT IS NOT ABOUT BEING FUNNY:

I am loyal to my friends. When somebody is mean to one of my friends I notice and I want to defend them, even if I do not always know how.

He stared at the sentence. He read it twice. It felt true.

He closed the journal. He slept. For the first time in a long time, he slept the whole night.

At school the next day, he was quieter than usual. He did not crack his usual lunch joke. Theo, across the table, noticed. Theo notices everything. Theo did not say anything — but he caught Jordan's eye for a second, and gave him a small look that meant *I see that you are different today. You do not have to perform. I am not going to make you.*

Jordan caught the look. He nodded back.

A week later, Jordan added another sentence to his journal.

I am a good observer. I notice when people are sad. I do not always know how to help, but I notice.

Two weeks after that:

I love drawing maps. I never told anybody this because it is not funny and it is not cool. I love it anyway.

Three weeks after that:

I cried when our neighbor's old cat died last year. I told my mom I was fine. I was not fine. I had really loved that cat.

By February, Jordan had written nineteen true things about himself that were not about being funny.

He did not show the journal to anyone. He did not have to. The journal was for him.

But by February, something had changed. Jordan was, in class, sometimes quiet. Sometimes funny. Sometimes neither. Sometimes both. The funny had become — instead of his whole identity — one of the things he did. It was, for the first time, a tool and not a cage.

This is what talking to yourself kindly makes possible.

It does not make the Inner Critic disappear. It just gives the Inner Critic a second voice to argue with. And the second voice, given practice, gets stronger.

By the time Jordan was in fifth grade, the Inner Critic was no longer the loudest voice in his head. The Inner Coach was. And the Inner Coach knew his name. The Inner Coach knew that Jordan was loyal, and a good observer, and a map-drawer, and a kid who had loved a neighbor's cat.

But that is two years from now.

For December of third grade — what matters is that Jordan, in a small office near the highway, had been seen.

That was the beginning.